

mail of the week

difference, Chinese put a lot of pressure on the athletes because winning a medal is a matter of national honour. If Indians want to show their interest and enjoy the game, the American system is good but if they want to win, the Chinese system is better because the financing, manpower and timing are better guaranteed.

ASOKE C. BANERJEE, on e-mail

On the Wing

There should be some kind of public audit of the foreign trips undertaken by the bureaucrats so as to establish their propriety ("Babus' Flights of Fancy", September 15). The exchequer should not be made to bleed unjustly by their jaunts which otherwise have no utility for the country and its people.

V.K. TANGRI, on e-mail

Challenges Galore

Pakistan is fraught with problems which don't augur well for Asif Zardari's presidency and the future of the country. Zardari will prove his acumen if he is able to rein in the rogue elements including the ISI, promotes a solution to the Kashmir issue and is able to keep the army and the disparate and quarrelling politicians in check ("Advantage Zardari", September 8).

R.J. KHURANA, Bhopal

Delayed, Not Denied

Sanjeev Nanda's conviction after nine long years will also serve as a wake-up call for the judiciary against attempts to sabotage trials by influential people, hostile witnesses and unscrupulous lawyers

("Driving the Point Home", September 15).

J. AKSHAY, on e-mail

Facts of Fiction

This is to clarify some matters brought up in Dilip Bobb's otherwise insightful review of my book, *The Homecoming* ("Lost in the Vale", September 15). I didn't visit Kashmir as a journalist but as a private citizen with no organisational backing. It made me vulnerable to the hard facts of life in the state as the

average Kashmiri, and this is why people opened up to me. My last two books, *Hangman's Journal* and *The Homecoming*, are neither thrillers nor spy stories: comparisons with Le Carre, Deighton, and Dan Brown might be misleading. Also, since all my thrillers predate Brown's, calling me his clone seems untenable. The title of one of my book was also slightly off: it's *Sniper*, not *The Sniper*.

SHASHI WARRIER, on e-mail



SUBIR HALDER

Politicians like Mamata Banerjee can push West Bengal decades behind in progress ("Tata Bye Bye?", September 15). She is getting even with the Left Front with her anti-Tata stir. It is nothing but another way of gaining political mileage out of the whole crisis.

MADHU AGARWAL, Delhi

What if India Inc reacts in response to Mamata Banerjee's action in Singur by boycotting West Bengal and pulling out all its proposed projects from the state? Who will be responsible for its after-effects on the state's economy?

ROHIT KUMAR, on e-mail

The Government should try and get the proposed Land Acquisition (Amendment) Bill through in the House to avoid Singur-like situation in the near future.

SHYAM SINGH, on e-mail

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Years Ago in India Today

OCTOBER 16-31, 1978



Bhiladwala

A Half Baked Measure

Two years ago, in the course of an interview, Colleen Bhiladwala, the green-eyed chief air hostess of Air-India lamented: "The average span of a stewardess is three years. The main reason they leave is to get married". Now, air hostesses may no longer be confronted with the same problem. A proposal was put before a board meeting of Air-India and Indian Airlines, to allow the girls to combine their flying careers with matrimony. Air hostesses will be permitted to marry on condition that they have put in four years of service and don't get pregnant. If they do, they will be forced to resign. The move looks a half-baked measure which has been received with mixed feelings in airline circles. The motive is to keep hostesses on the rolls—about 70 of them resign every year. But air hostesses grouched the pregnancy condition. They asked: "If other airlines allow hostesses to have kids, why can't we? A woman doesn't go out of order once she is a mother, does she?"

—Khaliq Mohamed

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